Build a buyer persona from evidence - complete text version

You are preparing for a discovery call with a data analyst at Ordinary Systems, a fictional technology company. Use Carla’s fictional case from a similar company to build a practice persona and plan questions. At work, check a persona against customer research and what your contact tells you. You will read the case, then build the persona one section at a time: who they are, what they care about, their pain points, how to engage them and a key insight. For each section, choose only the statements the case supports. If a choice is not right, the feedback explains why and you can try again. Then use your persona to choose an opening for the call, and finish by comparing your persona with what the case supports. The company and the people are fictional. This activity is not scored, and nothing you choose or write is stored or sent anywhere unless you save a text file yourself. Allow about 15 minutes.

How to use this version

You can do every stage on paper or in a document. Read the case, then draw a table with five rows: who they are, what they care about, pain points, how to engage them and key insight. For each of the first four rows, choose 3 or 4 statements from the list below that the case supports, and write them in your table. Then read the feedback for every statement and compare it with your choices. If you chose differently, revise your table. After two unsuccessful tries on a section, read its supported statements. Work through the sections in order, as in the interactive version.

The customer case

Read the fictional case of Carla Hernandez, a data analyst at Primer Systems, a company that develops electronic health record software for healthcare networks. Use its five passages as the evidence for this exercise.

Passage 1: Role

In her role, Carla manages large amounts of healthcare data, making sure it is accurate, consistent and usable across several systems. She develops analytical reports that guide internal leadership decisions and show value to external healthcare clients. She also supports compliance efforts, including audits, and makes sure data processes follow strict industry rules. Her work makes her a bridge between the technical side of data management and the broader business goals of the organisation.

Passage 2: Goal

Carla’s main goal is to streamline data analysis and reporting so that Primer Systems can give healthcare providers timely, accurate and actionable insights. She wants to modernise how the company manages and interprets data by reducing inefficiencies and improving automation. By doing this, she hopes to help Primer Systems stand out as a leader in healthcare technology and keep its software competitive and trusted by clients.

Passage 3: The business problem

Outdated and disconnected platforms make it difficult to produce reliable reports quickly. That delays decisions and weakens customer confidence. Carla needs solutions that simplify integration between systems, automate repetitive tasks and give greater security for sensitive patient information. Without these improvements, Primer Systems risks falling behind competitors that offer more efficient, compliant and scalable platforms.

Passage 4: Challenges

Healthcare data is becoming more complex as the company grows, which makes it harder to keep data both accurate and efficient. Strict compliance requirements add pressure, because even small errors can have significant consequences. Budget limits restrict how quickly new technology can be adopted. Teams used to existing workflows resist change, which makes it difficult to put new ways of working in place. Carla has to balance innovation with caution.

Passage 5: The bigger picture

Carla’s role connects to Primer Systems’ larger objectives: expanding the use of its health record platform and improving patient outcomes through better use of data. By keeping data processes efficient, accurate and compliant, she supports the company’s mission to provide trusted, scalable healthcare solutions. Her analytics show clients the value of the platform, so her daily responsibilities line up with the company’s long-term plans for growth and market leadership. Give your persona a fictional name (optional). A name makes a persona easier to refer to with your team. Use an invented name, not a real person’s.

Section 1 of 5: Who they are

Describe the role, responsibilities and position stated in this fictional case. Choose 3 or 4 statements supported by the case; whether similar details apply to a real contact would need checking.

- A data analyst at a large technology company, working with data across several systems. - Supported by the case. Feedback: Supported by Passage 1: the analyst manages large amounts of data across several systems. This practice persona keeps the role details supported by the fictional case; whether they apply to another analyst would need checking.
- Responsible for accurate, consistent and usable data, and for reports that guide leadership decisions. - Supported by the case. Feedback: Supported by Passage 1: accuracy, consistency and usability, and reports for internal leadership.
- Supports compliance work, including audits. - Supported by the case. Feedback: Supported by Passage 1.
- Sits between the technical side of data management and the wider business goals. - Supported by the case. Feedback: Supported by Passage 1, which describes the role as a bridge between the two.
- Needs simpler links between systems and less repetitive manual work. - In the case, but in a different section. Feedback: This is in the case (Passage 3), but it describes what the buyer needs. It belongs under “What they care about”, not “Who they are”.
- In their late thirties, with two children and a keen interest in running. - Not supported by the case. Feedback: Not supported. The case says nothing about age, family or hobbies. Invented personal detail makes a persona feel real, but it can send your sales approach in the wrong direction.

Section 2 of 5: What they care about

Outline the buyer’s main goals and priorities, and what matters most to them in their role. Choose 3 or 4 statements that the case supports.

- Timely, accurate and useful insights for the people who rely on their reports. - Supported by the case. Feedback: Supported by Passage 2: the goal is timely, accurate and actionable insights.
- Reducing inefficiencies and improving automation in how data is managed. - Supported by the case. Feedback: Supported by Passage 2.
- Helping the company stand out as a trusted leader whose products stay competitive. - Supported by the case. Feedback: Supported by Passage 2.
- Simple links between systems, less repetitive work and stronger security for sensitive data. - Supported by the case. Feedback: Supported by Passage 3, which says what the buyer needs from any solution.
- Teams used to existing workflows may resist change. - In the case, but in a different section. Feedback: This is in the case (Passage 4), but it is an obstacle, not a goal. It belongs under “Pain points”.
- Winning an industry award for data innovation this year. - Not supported by the case. Feedback: Not supported. Nothing in the case mentions awards. Goals in a persona should come from the research, not from what seems plausible.

Section 3 of 5: Pain points

Identify the key challenges or obstacles that may stop the buyer from reaching their goals. Choose 3 or 4 statements that the case supports.

- Outdated, disconnected platforms make reliable reports slow, which delays decisions and weakens customer confidence. - Supported by the case. Feedback: Supported by Passage 3.
- Strict compliance rules mean even small errors can have serious consequences. - Supported by the case. Feedback: Supported by Passage 4.
- Budget limits slow how quickly new technology can be adopted. - Supported by the case. Feedback: Supported by Passage 4.
- Teams used to existing workflows resist change. - Supported by the case. Feedback: Supported by Passage 4.
- Wants to help the company stand out as a trusted leader. - In the case, but in a different section. Feedback: This is in the case (Passage 2), but it is a goal, not an obstacle. It belongs under “What they care about”.
- Distrusts every cloud supplier and avoids meeting them. - Not supported by the case. Feedback: Not supported. The case says nothing about attitudes to suppliers. Assuming a negative attitude could close a conversation before it starts.

Section 4 of 5: How to engage them

Suggest approaches, conversation starters or value propositions that would resonate with this buyer. These are judgements drawn from the case, not facts stated in it, so check each one against the evidence. Choose 3 or 4 that fit.

- Start by asking how long reliable reports take today and what the delay means for decisions. - Supported by the case. Feedback: A good fit. It follows the pain point in Passage 3: slow reports delay decisions. It is a judgement based on the case.
- Show how connecting systems and automating repetitive tasks could speed up accurate reporting. - Supported by the case. Feedback: A good fit. It follows what the buyer needs in Passage 3. It is a judgement based on the case.
- Raise security and compliance early and plainly, rather than leaving them until late in the conversation. - Supported by the case. Feedback: A good fit. Passages 3 and 4 make security and strict compliance central to this buyer. It is a judgement based on the case.
- Acknowledge limited budgets and resistance to change, and talk about adopting new tools in steps people can accept. - Supported by the case. Feedback: A good fit. Passage 4 names budget limits and resistance to change. It is a judgement based on the case.

- Data is becoming more complex as the company grows. - In the case, but in a different section. Feedback: This is in the case (Passage 4), but it describes a challenge, not an approach. It belongs under “Pain points”.
- Lead with a long list of the newest platform features and their technical details. - Not supported by the case. Feedback: Not a good fit. Engagement ideas should start from the buyer’s goals and problems. A feature list answers a question the buyer has not asked and swaps their goals for your product.

Section 5 of 5: Key insight

Choose the one takeaway that should guide how you approach this buyer. A strong insight names a core motivation and a challenge, not just a list of job tasks.

- They want to modernise reporting and automation so their company stays a trusted leader, but compliance rules, tight budgets and resistance to change mean they need steps that are secure and easy to justify. - Best fit. Feedback: That fits. It joins a core motivation (Passage 2) to the barriers that limit it (Passages 3 and 4), so it tells you how to approach them.
- They analyse data and produce reports for leadership and clients. - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. This is true (Passage 1), but it only lists tasks. It does not say what drives them or what stands in their way, so it does not help you decide how to approach them.
- They want the most advanced analytics features available, whatever the cost. - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. The case describes limited budgets and puts goals and problems ahead of features. This replaces the buyer’s priorities with the product’s.
- They mainly want to cut costs. - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. The case names budget limits as a barrier, not cost cutting as a goal. Their stated goals are timely, accurate insight and a more competitive, trusted company.

Use your persona

Your discovery call is about to start. Which opening makes the best use of the persona you have just built?

- “I’d like to understand how reporting works for your team today. How long does it take to get reports you can trust, and what does a delay mean for decisions?” - Best fit. Feedback: That fits. It starts from the goal and pain point in your persona, invites the buyer to talk and shows that you have prepared.
- “Let me start by walking you through everything our platform can do.” - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. This leads with features. Your persona says the buyer cares about goals and problems, so start there.
- “Tell me everything about your company.” - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. This is too general. A persona exists so that you can ask something specific and relevant instead.

- “I know your budget must be tight, so let me start with a discount.” - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. Budget limits are a pain point in the case, but opening with a discount assumes the answer and skips what the buyer wants to solve.

Compare and reflect

Here is your persona next to everything the case supports for each section. Note where your answers match and where they differ. Differences show you where you could refine the persona.

Who they are

Supported by the case:

- A data analyst at a large technology company, working with data across several systems.
- Responsible for accurate, consistent and usable data, and for reports that guide leadership decisions.
- Supports compliance work, including audits.
- Sits between the technical side of data management and the wider business goals.

What they care about

Supported by the case:

- Timely, accurate and useful insights for the people who rely on their reports.
- Reducing inefficiencies and improving automation in how data is managed.
- Helping the company stand out as a trusted leader whose products stay competitive.
- Simple links between systems, less repetitive work and stronger security for sensitive data.

Pain points

Supported by the case:

- Outdated, disconnected platforms make reliable reports slow, which delays decisions and weakens customer confidence.
- Strict compliance rules mean even small errors can have serious consequences.
- Budget limits slow how quickly new technology can be adopted.
- Teams used to existing workflows resist change.

How to engage them

Supported by the case:

- Start by asking how long reliable reports take today and what the delay means for decisions.
- Show how connecting systems and automating repetitive tasks could speed up accurate reporting.
- Raise security and compliance early and plainly, rather than leaving them until late in the conversation.
- Acknowledge limited budgets and resistance to change, and talk about adopting new tools in steps people can accept.

How would you refine your persona after this comparison? Name one section you would change and why. In the interactive version, Save my persona downloads your persona, your opening and your reflection as a text file. An empty reflection prompts: Write a short reflection before saving. A persona built from evidence gives you a structure for a confident conversation: you know who the buyer is, what they care about, what holds them back and how to open.